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prices and the remainder at world-free market prices then sugar-cane quotas which would add up to the production of 160,000 tons of sugar could be given to each farmer; and for this a price should be paid for cane which is in keeping with the high price received for this amount of sugar. For cane production in excess of the quota, a price which reflects the low price received for the sugar could be paid. This would have the effect of curtailing sugar production to levels which are profitable in the national sense and would lead to a better pattern of land use in the island.

Quotas to farmers are usually objected to for the reason that the system tends to make the production structure rigid among farms by maintaining the inefficient and preventing the efficient from expanding. However, it is doubtful that there is much flexibility in the present narrow production structure and lack of scope for expansion of acreages on many farms. Moreover, allowing quotas to be transferable may be one way of remedying the problem.

Too much attention seems to have been directed at small farms for the encouragement of food crops, whereas estates have been virtually ignored. It seems, for example, that preparation lands on estates are not being fully utilized for food crop production. About 20 per cent of cane lands should come under this category every year. It is estimated that about 50,000 acres of lands on estates are under cane which means that about 10,000 acres per year are under preparation. However, Table 2 shows that only about 7,000 acres are now under food crops on estates.

Any diversification programme that is to succeed must encompass the estate sector. Estates are in a better position to stand the initial risks involved and their higher levels of management, larger capital and better quality lands could give them a greater chance of success. Moreover, since they control most of the farm land area of the country they could make a larger impact on the problem in a much shorter time.

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